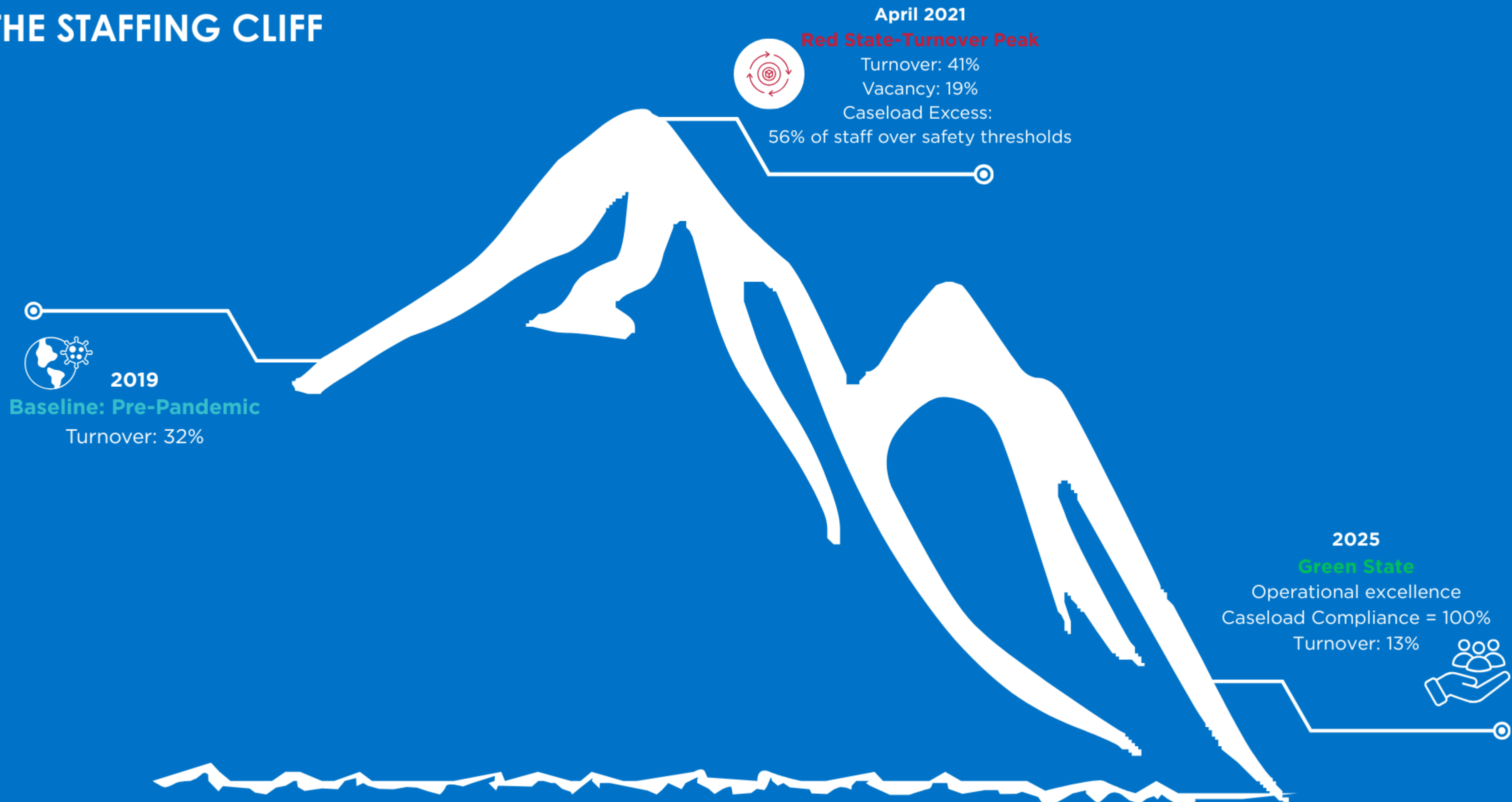


A Blueprint for Sustaining Workforce Stability in Child Welfare: A Strategic Evaluation of Workforce Stability at Children's Wisconsin Child Welfare, 2021-2025

Institute for
Child & Family
Well-Being

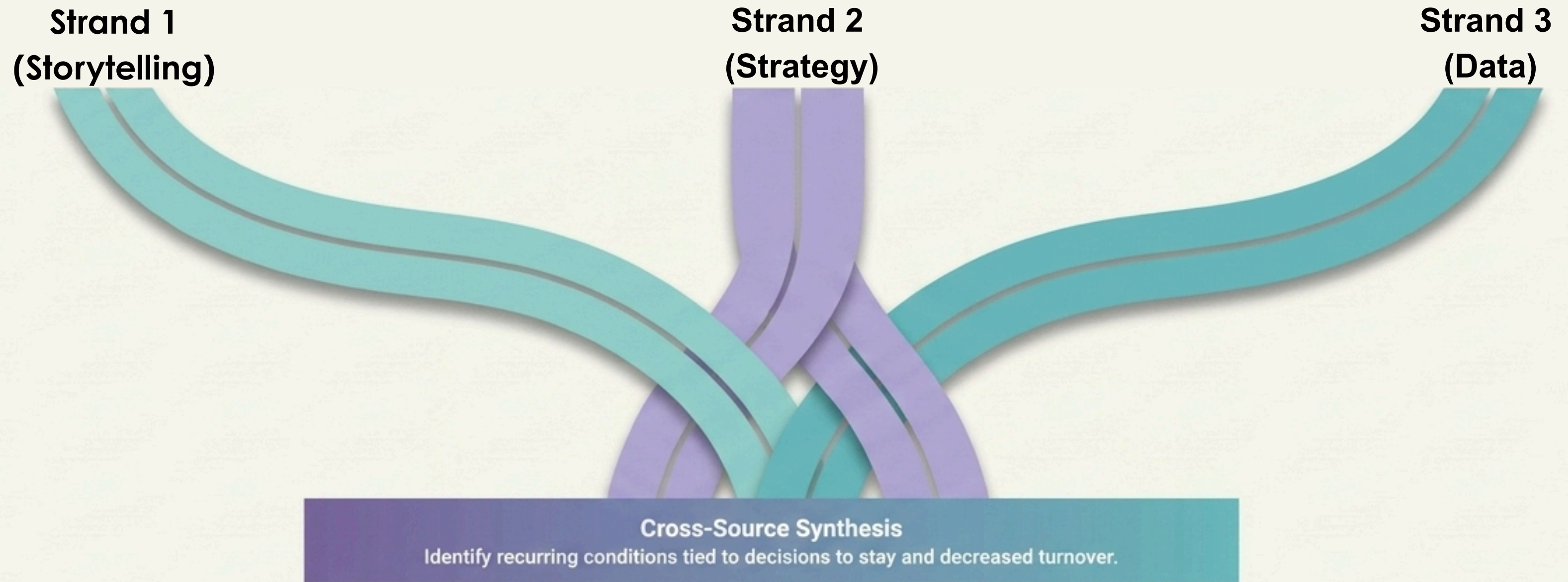


THE STAFFING CLIFF



Strategic Learning & The Evidence Braid

By synthesizing insights from more than 40 contributors across all organizational levels, ICFW identified the specific pillars of stability that countered the high demands of child welfare work and drove a historic reduction in staff turnover.





Pillar 1: Supportive & Responsive Leadership

Transitioning from “firefighting” to active advocacy.

Retention spiked when leaders shifted from crisis-driven micromanagement to proactive support. Leaders actively prioritized personhood over productivity, creating visible, responsive support structures that **rebuilt** psychological safety.

“My supervisor, she checks in on me as a person, not just as a case manager. Knowing that she has my back if a case gets too heavy makes all the difference.”

-Case Manager

THE 5 PILLARS OF STABILITY



Pillar 2: Hybrid Autonomy & Work-Life Flexibility

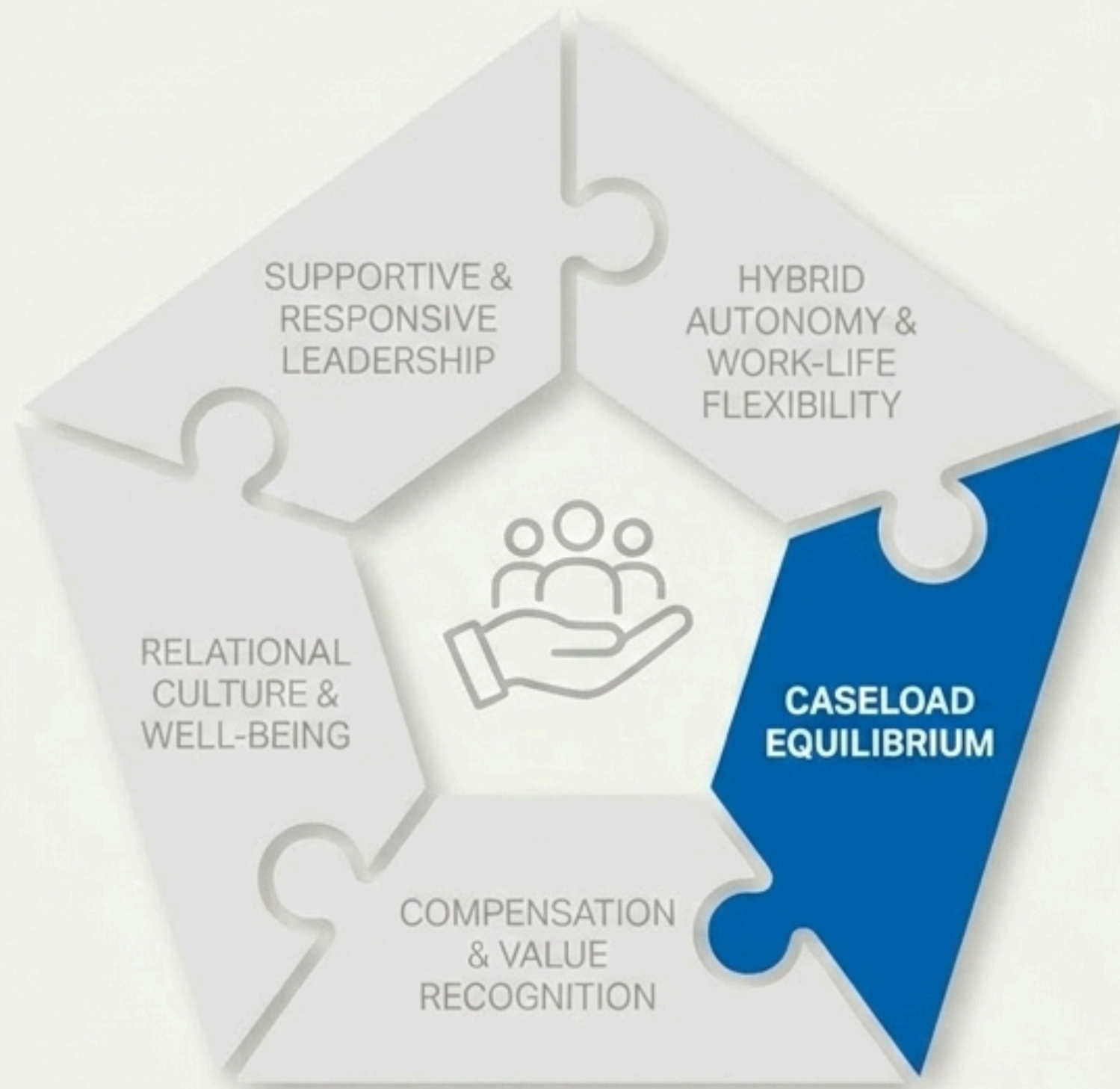
The "Office-by-Need" model as a sign of professional respect.

Moving beyond strict schedules, the agency trusted staff as professionals to manage their own time and locations. This single structural shift yielded a 92% consensus (23 of 25 surveyed) identifying flexibility as a primary retention driver.

“ Having that balance where I’m not tethered to an office desk for eight hours... it respects my time as a professional.

-Training Specialist

THE 5 PILLARS OF STABILITY



Pillar 3: Caseload Equilibrium

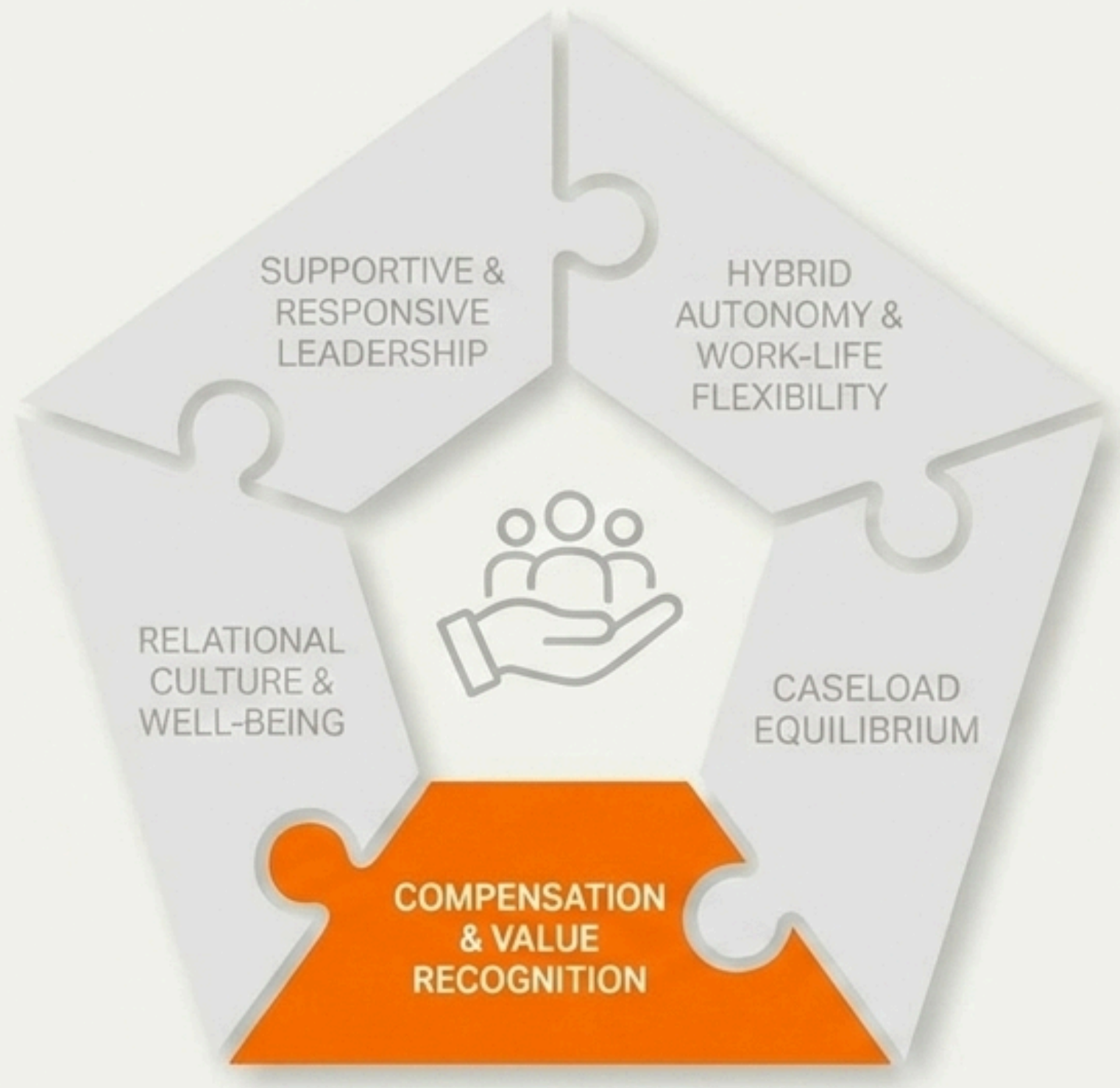
Reclaiming the purpose of the work.

Rigorous, uncompromising protection of the ~15-child safety limit. Leadership achieved this through a “Workload Protection” suite, executing stop lists for non-essential meetings, deploying case aides for logistics, and utilizing volunteer sitters to relieve frontline strain.

“There were times where I had almost 30 kids... Now they try to keep our caseloads at 15. I can function more efficiently and ensure kids are safe.”

-Case Manager

THE 5 PILLARS OF STABILITY



Pillar 4: Compensation & Value Recognition

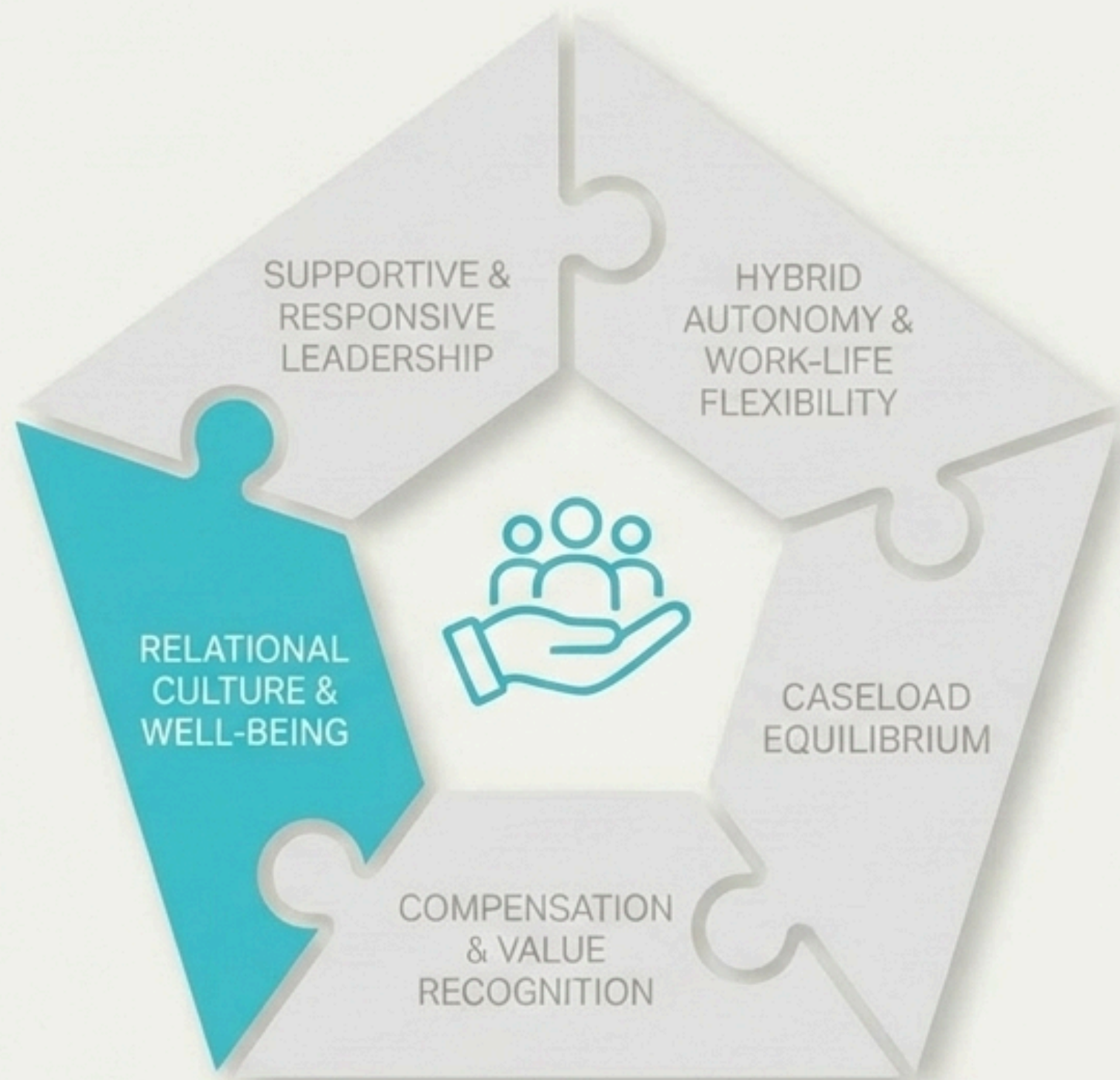
Resetting the financial floor.

Implementing a decisive 19% market adjustment. This acted as a critical “value reset” for case managers, proving organizational investment and ensuring that financial stress did not compound the inherent trauma of the work.

“I enjoyed the work previously, but it paid terrible... it made me feel like the agency actually realized what we were worth.”

-Case Manager

THE 5 PILLARS OF STABILITY



Pillar 5: Relational Culture & Well-Being

The power of being “seen.”

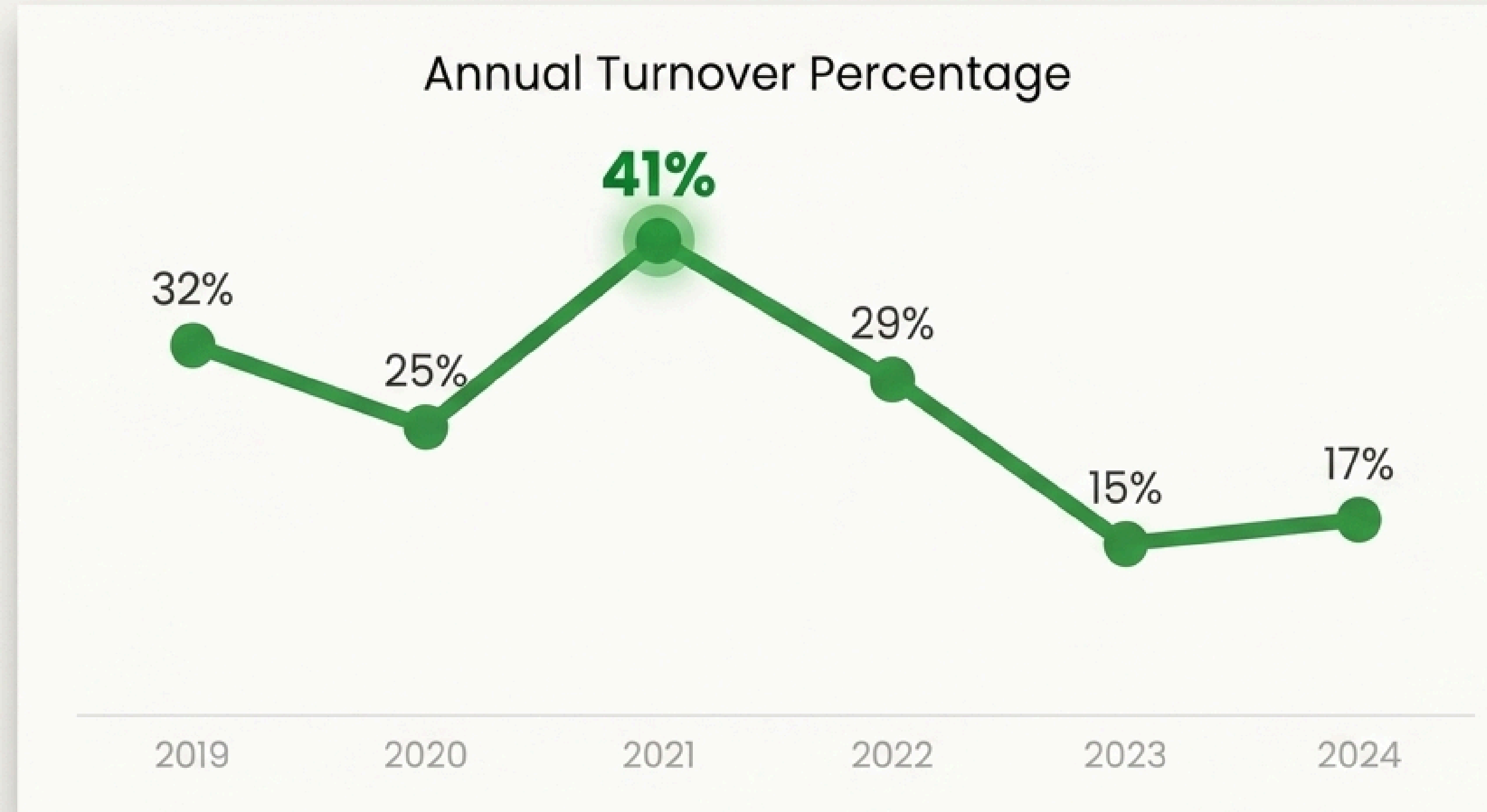
Normalizing mental health conversations, fostering peer connection, and building everyday cultures of care. The work became survivable because leadership explicitly recognized the emotional toll and treated staff as humans first.

“I remember getting a handwritten note from our VP...and it just said, ‘I see you...and I appreciate you.’ It meant so much to me at a time when things were really, really hard.”

-Training Specialist

The Proof of Stability (The “Green” State)

The workforce didn't just survive; it stabilized.



Turnover Plummeted

Fell from the 41% peak in 2021 to a sustained 13–17% by 2024/2025.



Sustained Growth

Recruitment outpaced separations for 36 consecutive months.



Operational Excellence

Achieved 100% compliance with the 15-child safety limit (up from 56% non-compliance).

Key Insight: The 5 Pillars successfully balanced the Job Demands–Resources scales, allowing the agency to return to high-quality, proactive child welfare.

The Sustainability Playbook

Dimension		Red State (2021)		Green State (2025)
Leadership	→	Reactive Firefighting	→	Proactive Advocacy
Autonomy	→	Schedule Micromanagement	→	Professional Trust (Office-by-Need)
Workload	→	Systemic Overload (25-30 cases)	→	Caseload Equilibrium (15 cases max)

The Transferable Insight

Organizations cannot control the “front door” of court-ordered intakes, but they can control the resilience of their internal systems. The 5 Pillars act as a replicable blueprint for systemic stability.

“Getting past the crisis allowed us to embrace the opportunity to return to a place of quality; it has been remarkable to see.” -**Child Welfare Program Director**

Workforce Retention & Well-Being

During the COVID-19 pandemic, Children's Wisconsin's Child Welfare team faced high turnover, rising caseloads, and staff fatigue.

In response, leadership implemented strategies—including pay increases, workload redesign, hybrid flexibility, supportive leadership, and consistent recognition—to improve staff well-being, engagement, and continuity of care for families.

What makes your approach effective?

CW leadership addressed the staffing crisis with urgency and data-driven insight, analyzing turnover, vacancies and caseloads alongside employee feedback. This informed five core strategies—pay increases, workload redesign, hybrid flexibility, supportive leadership, and consistent recognition—that stabilized caseloads, rebuilt trust, and reconnected staff to a shared purpose. The effectiveness of these strategies was later confirmed through formal evaluation.

What's a transferable insight or lesson?

In child and family serving systems, pairing workforce data with lived staff input enables phased feedback-driven changes that can rebuild organizational trust and stabilize retention. This Bright Spot offers a pragmatic playbook that other like agencies can draw from.

Learn more: <https://childrenswi.org/who-we-are/community-programs/child-welfare-services> & icfw@uwm.edu